



ZOOMING AHEAD Once completed, the Regional Rapid Transit System (RTS), will connect Meerut with Delhi

Haldia

Higher up the eastern coast there is Haldia in West Bengal. For Mrinal Kanti Bera, moving into Haldia in 2006 was a life-changing decision. Bera, 44, runs a restaurant near the Haldia port that caters to a wide array of locals—from daily wagers to white-collar employees from the port complex and manufacturing and refining industries. Starting off as a wage labourer, Bera has since turned into a successful entrepreneur.

“When I arrived here, there were hardly any permanent restaurants in the then newly promoted industrial area. Thus, after gathering some savings, I started on my own. I couldn’t have achieved anything close to this if I had stayed in my village,” says Bera, who hails from a village located some 50 km away from the port city.

Being a major industrial and cargo hub, Haldia attracts thousands every year, not only blue-collar workers from adjacent districts but also professionals in search of white-collar jobs. Apart from adding to its growing population pool and the local economy, the influx of migrants has effected a drastic change in the landscape.

Governed by the Haldia Development Authority, the town is finally seeing the launch of mid-scale housing projects. For a town that was familiar with standalone homes, projects such as gated community developments by the likes of Kolkata-based Shristi Group near the Haldia International Sports Complex are a major leap forward. The 35-acre residential project, with some 300 apartments, is one of the largest such developments in the region.

Moreover, the Union government’s push for inland waterways is opening up new opportunities. Take the Va-

ranasi-Haldia inland waterway project for instance. The project aims to boost exports of agricultural commodities and manufactured goods from Uttar Pradesh, which is expected to increase from ₹1.56 lakh crore in 2022 to ₹3 lakh crore by 2026.

There are challenges, however. Despite being the focal point of development of the state government for years, there are few large-scale infrastructural projects, apart from the dock complex and private industrial complexes. “Haldia has major potential, but we are yet to unlock it. While the region is currently self-sufficient in terms of amenities and infrastructure, it is likely to face challenges in the future as major projects are still missing,” says Ramlal Sahu, who owns inland fisheries units.

The Road to the Top

While cities like Meerut, Vapi, Haldia, and Tirunelveli are undergoing rapid transformation, they face significant challenges. One major concern is the strain on existing infrastructure, which may struggle to keep pace with growing populations and expanding industries.

Additionally, the rapidly increasing demand for skilled labour may outstrip the current supply, posing hurdles for industries reliant on specialised expertise.

Policymakers will need to pay urgent attention to these cities, along with many others across India, to ensure that developmental gains are more dispersed and not concentrated in a few metropolises.

(With inputs from Krishna Gopalan, Arnab Dutta and Ridhima Bhatnagar) **BT**

@imNavneetDubey